



BEIRUT LEBANON

Raw Passion in Beirut

Invigorating and exasperating, vibrant and serene, beautiful and dilapidated – Beirut is all things to all people. Though plagued by strife, it refuses to be beaten. It has emerged from a troubled past as a cosmopolitan crucible of cultures, and from its street life to its nightlife, Beirut's impulses and passions are as raw as can be – just like the city's favorite meat dish, *kibbeh nayyeh*.



Built on a promontory jutting out into the Mediterranean, Beirut is ever the show-off. But as difficult as it might be to imagine today's vivacious capital playing second fiddle to a neighboring town, it was once deemed less important than the Phoenician trading ports of Sidon and Byblos. It wasn't until the Romans began using Beirut as a military base and commercial hub that it really began to blossom. The ruins of Roman bathhouses can still be seen in the central area, today a buoyant shopping and entertainment district, which itself sprang out of a more recent set of ruins left behind by the devastating 15-year civil war.

Bullet-peppered buildings and army checkpoints serve as a reminder of the city's struggles, but years of conflict and political instability have taught the people to seize life and live it with gusto. This natural energy and *joie de vivre* can be felt on any trip to Beirut, from the daily human tide that flows up and down its sweeping Corniche to the frenetic cafés and bars that line Gemmayze's vivid Rue Gourard. Amble along Hamra Street, and the street food of sizzling *shawarma* grilled meats and falafel will be hard to resist. But

leave room for lunch, which in Beirut is long, leisurely, and all about meze. Guaranteed to be among the array of dishes is *kibbeh nayyeh*, one of Lebanon's most famous delicacies. It's raw lamb, pulverized with cracked bulgur wheat and chopped onion until mousse-soft, often whipped into swirly shapes and served drizzled with olive oil and garnished with fresh mint. Its creamy texture and rich flavor goes perfectly with green olives, pickled chili peppers, and zesty tabbouleh (parsley and bulgur salad).

Like so many Levantine dishes, it may well have its roots in ancient Syria. Some villages, like Ehden in northern Lebanon – considered by some to be the capital of *kibbeh nayyeh* – have claimed it as their own. But for centuries, wherever there were sheep and goats in Lebanon, *kibbeh nayyeh* would be pounded in stone mortars called *jurns*, the sound resonating through the village. The beauty of finding *kibbeh nayyeh* in Beirut lies in discovering regional variations – one recipe might have coarse bulgur, while another might use more olive oil. But as any master of *kibbeh nayyeh* preparation will tell you, the secret ultimately lies in the freshness, quality, and leanness of the meat.



Above Much of Beirut's historic central district has required reconstruction, and is now a vibrant shopping, dining, and entertainment area

Beirut's Farmers' Market

Souk El Tayeb (www.soukeltayeb.com), which meets every Saturday on a site near the Exhibition Center, is Lebanon's first weekly farmers' market; it brings together over 100 producers and artisans. Founded by Kamal Mouzawak, the souk showcases the seasonal produce of farmers from all over Lebanon, but it's more than just a market. As well as aiming to preserve Lebanon's natural heritage, it also seeks to promote coexistence, social interaction, and an environmentally friendly lifestyle. **Tawlet** (www.tawlet.com) is the organization's cooperative kitchen, which offers the creations of a different regional cook each day. In addition, the team holds regular **Food & Feast festivals** across Lebanon, from the fruit-growing villages of Mount Lebanon to the herb-growers of the south.

Three Days in Beirut

Lebanon is small and geographically diverse, so it's possible to swim in the morning, ski in the afternoon, and go clubbing in the city at night. With a few days to explore, you can revel in Beirut's infectious energy, enjoy the resorts of Mount Lebanon, and recover at the beach clubs around the capital.

DAY ONE After a morning stroll along the **Corniche**, have an espresso in a **Hamra café** among the students from the American University. Head east to the beautiful **Mohammed al-Amin mosque** on the site of the Green Line that divided Beirut during the civil war. Then check out the cafés and bars in the Christian neighborhoods of **Achrefiyeh** and **Gemmayze**.

DAY TWO Drive or take a taxi to the **Jeita Grotto** to see the impressive stalactites and stalagmites in the subterranean caverns. Then head on to the slopes of **Faraya Mzaar**, where the après-ski culture is every bit as lively as the skiing.

DAY THREE If the weather's fine, kick back at one of Beirut's beach clubs. **AUB Beach** has a wonderful ambience, while the **St. George Yacht Motor Club** is where the beautiful people go to hang out.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

From **Rafic Hariri International Airport** it's just a 10-minute **taxi** ride downtown; if you dislike haggling, choose a marked, registered white cab.

WHERE TO STAY

Port View Hotel (inexpensive) in the Mar Mikhael area is within walking distance of the bars and restaurants of Gemmayze. www.portviewhotel.blogspot.com

Marble Tower (moderate) is a comfortable and recently renovated hotel in the lively Hamra district. www.marbletowerhotel.com

Le Gray (expensive) is a modern luxury hotel in the revamped Central district. www.campbellgrayhotels.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

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